CHUTE STACK

Busywork goes in. Free time comes out.

FREE GUIDE FOR SMALL BUSINESS OWNERS

3 mistakes that send customers to your competitors

What happens to a new customer with and without a system behind your phone and inbox, plus a 5-minute self-check to see which ones you're making.

MISTAKE 01	Letting calls go to voicemail while you're busy
MISTAKE 02	Leaving after-hours inquiries until morning
MISTAKE 03	Letting quotes go quiet

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BEFORE WE START

The customer usually goes with whoever gets back first

Whether someone needs a new roof, an insurance quote, a house showing or a consultation, they rarely reach out to just one business. They call two or three, fill out a form or two, and go with the first one who gets back to them and sounds like they've got it handled. Price and reviews matter. Speed often decides it.

You're not losing to better competitors

Most lost customers never turn into a "no." They just stop waiting and go with someone else. You never hear about it, so it never shows up as a problem.

It's not a work-ethic problem

You can't answer the phone while you're with a client, and you shouldn't be answering emails at 10 PM. The fix is a system that responds for you, not working more hours.

How to use this guide

Each mistake shows the same moment two ways: how it usually goes, and how it goes with a simple system behind it. Tick the self-check boxes as you go.

What to do with your score

Count your ticks on the last page. It tells you which mistake is costing you most, and where to start.

MISTAKE 01

Letting calls go to voicemail while you're busy

Your phone rings while you're with a customer, on a job or in a meeting. You'll call back when you're free. By then they've already talked to someone else.

Without a system

TYPICAL

2:14 PM	New customer calls. You're with a client. It rings out to voicemail.
2:15 PM	They hang up without leaving a message and call the next business on Google.
2:31 PM	A competitor calls them back and books the appointment.
6:40 PM	You see a missed call from an unknown number. Maybe you call back, maybe you don't.
Result	**Customer lost. You never knew they existed.**

With a system

AUTOMATED

2:14 PM	New customer calls. You're with a client. It goes to voicemail.
2:14 PM	They get an instant reply: "Sorry we missed you, we're with a customer. What can we help with?"
2:15 PM	Their details land in one lead list, and you or your team get an alert.
3:05 PM	You call back between appointments, already knowing what they need.
Result	**Appointment booked. They felt answered within a minute.**

Run your own numbers. Example: you miss 5 calls a week, 1 in 4 of those would have bought, and an average customer is worth $8,000 to you. That's about 5 customers a month walking to someone else.

$40,000
/ MONTH IN EXAMPLE

SELF-CHECK · TICK IF TRUE

- [ ] When I'm busy with a customer, calls usually go to voicemail.
- [ ] Callers who don't leave a message don't get a call back.
- [ ] I don't know how many calls I missed last week.

MISTAKE 02

Leaving after-hours inquiries until morning

People shop at night and on weekends, after their own workday. Your website form, inbox and voicemail are open 24/7. Your response usually isn't.

Without a system

TYPICAL

Sat 8:52 PM	Someone fills out the contact form on your website.
Sat 8:52 PM	Nothing happens. No confirmation, no reply.
Sun	They contact two more businesses. One replies Sunday afternoon.
Mon 9:30 AM	Someone in your office finds the form in the inbox and calls.
Result	"Thanks, we already went with someone."

With a system

AUTOMATED

Sat 8:52 PM	Someone fills out the contact form on your website.
Sat 8:53 PM	Instant reply confirms you got it and offers times to talk.
Sat 8:58 PM	They pick Monday 10 AM. It goes straight on your calendar.
Mon 8:00 AM	Your morning list shows every weekend request, nothing buried in an inbox.
Result	Appointment booked before Monday even started.

Quick test you can do tonight. Fill out your own website form after 6 PM using a different email. Time how long it takes to get any reply at all.

?? hrs

YOUR TIME TO FIRST REPLY

SELF-CHECK · TICK IF TRUE

- [ ] My website form doesn't send an instant confirmation.
- [ ] Weekend requests usually wait until Monday.
- [ ] Form requests go to an inbox someone has to remember to check.

MISTAKE 03

Letting quotes go quiet

You did the work up front and sent the quote or proposal. Then nothing. Most businesses follow up once, maybe. Plenty of customers just needed a nudge at the right time.

Without a system

TYPICAL

Day 0	You send a $14,000 quote.
Day 1–6	No reply. You're busy with current customers.
Day 7	You mean to follow up. It slips.
Day 21	You remember. You call. They went with someone who checked in last week.
Result	**A quote you already did the work for, lost.**

With a system

AUTOMATED

Day 0	You send a $14,000 quote. It's logged as "Quote sent."
Day 2	Friendly check-in goes out: "Any questions on the quote?"
Day 5	Second follow-up, plus a reminder for you to call.
Day 10	Final note. Their reply moves the deal to "Won" or "Lost," so your list stays clean.
Result	**Every quote gets followed up, without you remembering.**

Count it up. How many quotes did you send in the last 60 days that never got a clear yes or no? Each one is work you already did and haven't been paid for.

__ quotes
OPEN WITH NO ANSWER

SELF-CHECK · TICK IF TRUE

- [ ] I follow up on quotes when I remember to.
- [ ] I couldn't tell you right now how many quotes are still open.
- [ ] Quotes live in my email, texts or a notebook, not one list.

YOUR SCORE

Count your ticks

Add up the boxes you ticked across all three mistakes.

0–2 ticks	**Tight.** You're ahead of most businesses. Keep an eye on your busy season, when these slip back in fastest.
3–5 ticks	**Slipping.** You're losing customers you never hear about. Start with whichever mistake has the most ticks.
6–9 ticks	**Losing customers every week.** New customers are reaching you and not getting through. This is fixable, and usually faster than people expect.

NEXT STEP · FREE

See exactly where customers slip away with the 24-Hour Missed-Call Test

I call your business after hours and send one test inquiry through your website, clearly labeled as a test. Then I send you a 2-minute video showing what a new customer actually experiences, and what fixed would look like. No call required.

01
I call after hours and submit your form

02
I time your response for 24 hours

03
You get a 2-minute video with the results

Get my free test →

getchutestack.com info@getchutestack.com

Timelines and dollar figures in this guide are illustrative examples, not guarantees. Your numbers will differ. Austin Helms · Chute Stack · Milford, PA